

Aesthetics Of Njingkook: Mupun Storytelling In The Digital Age

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Abstract

This paper discusses the systemic marginalisation of African oral performance systems by both legacy Eurocentric scholarship and contemporary extractive data architectures associated with digital colonialism. These dynamics frequently strip localised cultural heritage of its context, reducing it to commercialised entertainment. The study considers the articulation of dualistic indigenous aesthetic structures in Mupun performance culture; material beauty (men) and ethical truth (ret) within Njingkook, an established storytelling theatre of the Mupun society in Central Nigeria. It further explores strategies for digital preservation that avoid algorithmic flattening and epistemic distortion in the digital era. The research uses an emic, interpretive ethnographic approach based on the paradigm of Technauriture and develops a community-led digital workflow. Methodological procedures include high-definition cinematic capture (Sony FX30) and constrained Large Language Model (LLM) prompting to transcribe and translate live Mupun performances into 2D-animated assets for public distribution platforms such as YouTube. Principal analytical observations show a comparative structural typology between live and animated performance models, disclosing critical epistemic tensions: standard digital compression and fast-paced metrics tend to prioritise visual men while diminishing the somatic depth, paralinguistic pauses, and "copious" structural repetitions indispensable for sustaining the pedagogical and philosophical significance of ret. Theoretically, the paper argues that subverting algorithmic violence requires an operational policy model rooted in Indigenous Data Sovereignty (IDS), managed by local community unions such as the Mupun Cultural Development Association (MUCDA). Ultimately, this research repositions African performance studies and digital humanities by conceptualising oral traditions not as static historical relics, but as sovereign, living techno-vernacular practices capable of maintaining narrative sovereignty and systemic complexity within a highly digitised world landscape.

Keywords: Njingkook, Mupun, Technauriture, Indigenous Data Sovereignty, Digital Archive, Orality.

INTRODUCTION

In their different submissions, Mangvat, Fwatshak, Dakas and Bagudu have reported that "Nigeria's extensive ethnolinguistic diversity manifests in complex geopolitical transitional zones, particularly within the "cultural Middle Belt" of the Jos Plateau, where minority ethnic nationalities have historically resisted centralised state authority". Among these groups are the agrarian, Chadic-speaking Mupun people, whose socio-political philosophies, ethical frameworks, and historical genealogies are embedded in the evening storytelling theatre known as *Njingkook*. *Njingkook* functions not as ephemeral entertainment but as a sophisticated pedagogical, civic-judicial, and philosophical institution that sustains communal equity and transmits indigenous worldviews.

This research is grounded in a specific scholarly problem: the systemic devaluation and "normative injustice" within performance criticism, which stems from persistent Eurocentric colonial policies and postcolonial capitalist urbanisation. Traditional scholarship has often dismissed African oral performance structures as lacking intellectual merit, evaluating them

exclusively through Western-centric literate frameworks and neglecting the ways in which local communities define, perceive, and generate their own paradigms of beauty and truth (Okpewho, 30).

Despite its considerable socio-cultural significance, *Njingkook* remains significantly under-theorised. This marginalisation results from two primary historical factors. First, there is a persistent scarcity of scholarly literature on minority, non-Hausa Chadic-speaking performance arts, creating a substantial gap in contemporary African theatre scholarship. Second, the ongoing threat of globalisation seeks to assimilate minority ethnic identities into a singular metropolitan consumerist model, discarding localised oral epistemologies before they can be rigorously documented on their own terms, as reported by Newman (33).

To address this crisis in the twenty-first century, "Technauriture," defined as the symbiotic intersection of technology, auriture (oral literature), and conventional literature, emerges as the most appropriate theoretical framework. Rather than viewing digital platforms as instruments of cultural erasure, Technauriture posits that new media networks and computational models provide a productive environment for the adaptation, cross-boundary migration, and sovereign revitalisation of oral cultures (Kaschula, 5). This framework allows orality to be integrated into modern digital discourse without compromising its ancestral foundations according to wa Thiong'o (7).

This study differs fundamentally from previous scholarship on African oral performance. While traditional African theatre research and early documentation efforts primarily treat oral traditions as frozen, static artifacts of a pre-literate past to be preserved in passive, print-bound textuality—an approach exemplified in the classic structural anthologies of Ruth Finnegan (*Oral Literature in Africa*) and the descriptive frameworks of early scholars like Oyin Ogunba. This study actively positions *Njingkook* as a living, dynamic techno-vernacular practice. By deploying an immersive ethnographic methodology alongside an innovative, community-governed AI interface, this research moves beyond simple passive preservation. It directly confronts the predatory, data-extractive architectures of contemporary digital colonialism (Couldry and Mejias, 23), establishing a sovereign, modern computational archive controlled entirely by the indigenous community.

REVIEW OF RELEVANT LITERATURE

The formal documentation of African oral performance systems has been marked by an epistemic tension between structuralist textual approaches and the dynamic qualities of live execution. A central debate concerns whether the structural elements of oral performance function as restrictive, fixed templates or as adaptable frameworks for immediate, context-specific creation. (Kolawole 1-15) Albert Lord's oral-formulaic theory challenges text-centric assumptions about narrative preservation, demonstrating that oral epics are not memorised verbatim but are "composed in performance" through inherited traditional formulas (Ready 4; Lord 189). This structural flexibility shapes the psychodynamics of primary orality, as identified by Walter J. Ong. Ong argues that, in the absence of standard textuality, the human mind organises thought using highly specialised, redundant mnemonic frameworks (10). Expression in primary orality is fundamentally "redundant or 'copious'" because spoken language requires ongoing repetition to sustain a shared semantic space between speaker and listener (Ong 10).

Furthermore, Ong observes that oral expression is "empathetic and participatory rather than objectively distanced," engaging the audience as an active, collaborative force in validating the narrative moment (11).

A methodological disagreement persists regarding how to accurately capture these participatory dynamics without reducing them to mere linguistic text. Structural performance scholars often emphasise formal constraints, whereas interpretive ethnographers argue that textual documentation alone diminishes the social significance of performance. (Furniss and Gunner) Clifford Geertz's interpretive ethnography addresses this issue by advocating for "thick description," which differentiates between simple physical actions and complex, socially coded behaviours such as a burlesque wink (5). Geertz, Gratale, and Serap articulate that semiotic framework by stating that, "man is an animal suspended in webs of significance he himself has spun, I take culture to be those webs, and the analysis of it to be therefore not an experimental science in search of law but an interpretive one in search of meaning" (5, 4). In the context of *Njingkook*, Geertz's framework ensures that performance analysis extends beyond recording surface narrative plots to actively decoding the paralinguistic manoeuvres, somatic shifts, and moral pedagogies through which the Mupun community constructs its own reality.

The migration of high-context oral performance systems from traditional physical settings to digital networks creates a significant theoretical conflict between technological optimism and decolonial data critique. (Yékú, 10). Ngũgĩ wa Thiong'o's concept of "Technauriture" highlights the intersection among technology, auriture, and literature. Wa Thiong'o maintains that "language carries culture, and culture carries, particularly through orature, the entire body of values by which we come to perceive ourselves" (15). Rather than viewing digital platforms solely as instruments of cultural erasure, the technauritic paradigm posits that modern networks provide a fertile environment for the "creative adaptation, cross-boundary migration, and rebirth" of oral systems (Kaschula 41). In this framework, computational architectures serve as direct extensions of the ancestral voice. (Kaschula and Wolff, 6)

This optimistic perspective is contested by macro-level critiques regarding corporate data extraction. Nick Couldry and Ulises A. Mejias argue that contemporary digital architectures replicate historical colonial land appropriations by appropriating human life and cultural production through algorithmic processing, thereby establishing "a new era in human history where data is continuous with colonialism" (337). When general-purpose computational tools indiscriminately extract indigenous oral texts, they risk perpetuating digital colonialism, a process in which corporate digital platforms strip complex, sacred moral frameworks of their structural boundaries and reduce them to commodified, transient elements of Westernized consumer entertainment (Hussen et al. 45). This extraction is further intensified by what Shoshana Zuboff terms "surveillance capitalism," which she describes as an uninvited "expropriation of critical human experience" (12). Without intentional intervention, automated systems may misinterpret or erase the subtle tonal variations, rhythmic pauses, and localised ethical boundaries that master griots use to convey authoritative truths (Zuboff 12;).

Recent scholarship complicates the binary between digital emancipation and total colonial extraction. (Asiedu et al.) While general-purpose Large Language Models (LLMs) and automated tools have significantly advanced the documentation of endangered languages and transcription workflows (Varshney 1), they also introduce substantial localised epistemic risks.

Hussen et al. identify a dual threat: globalisation favours written or visual formats that undermine native oral transmission, and standard AI transcription models frequently fail to capture the contextual depth, tonal nuances, and performative essence of African oral storytelling (46). Agoi further demonstrates that, although computational logic can accurately decode and classify physical indigenous symbols, it is structurally incapable of reproducing the "spiritual intention" and immediate communal validation central to West African epistemologies (1.1.2). Standard transformer architectures, operating on secularised, linear logic, risk flattening recursive, cyclical indigenous temporalities into Westernised visual content (Agoi, 12). In response, this study proposes a community-led digital workflow for *Njingkook* theatre that introduces "ethical friction" into the technological pipeline (Dakwom, 5). By implementing a highly constrained system prompting framework governed by the Mupun Cultural Development Association (MUCDA), this research moves beyond descriptive preservation to offer an empirical, context-sensitive policy model grounded in Indigenous Data Sovereignty (IDS) (23).

EMERGING PARADIGMS IN ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE, DIGITAL HERITAGE, AND DECOLONIAL ARCHIVING

The intersection of digital heritage preservation and African digital humanities has become a contested domain in which computational logic and indigenous epistemologies often conflict. Dwivedi observes that the contemporary "integration of advanced digital technologies" such as big data processing, virtual reality, and digital archives has resulted in a "major epistemological and methodological shift in the ways historical knowledge is interpreted, managed, and distributed globally" (11). However, this digital transformation is significantly undermined by persistent structural imbalances. Dwivedi further notes that investment in digital infrastructure across Sub-Saharan Africa accounts for less than two per cent of GDP in several nations, a disparity that "has exacerbated the divide between highly facilitated digital research institutions and poorly facilitated heritage sites" (1). This imbalance intensifies debates concerning "data colonialism, digital inequality, and digital dependency," demonstrating that while technological advancements appear to democratize knowledge production, they also "generate novel forms of exclusion, dependency, and cultural asymmetries" (6). Therefore, in the context of African performance archiving, digital networks should not be regarded as politically neutral tools. Instead, they function as corporate spaces that often restrict local agency and reinforce Western-centric models of curation.

This tension is further amplified when automated computational systems are used to preserve intangible cultural heritage and indigenous oral storytelling. While contemporary machine learning systems are effective at basic cataloguing, Agoi notes that standard algorithmic tools are ultimately "unable to reproduce spiritual intention and group validation" (19). African indigenous epistemologies are fundamentally relational, embedding knowledge within localised rituals, myths, and shared physical spaces. In contrast, mainstream "AI prioritises transparency, reproducibility, and data accessibility" (2). This misalignment raises significant ethical concerns, as data show that "62 per cent of West African respondents expressed concern that digital technologies would diminish indigenous spirituality" (14). To address this reductionism, Pansoni et al. advocate for a specialised, domain-specific AI ethics framework that moves beyond abstract guidelines and actively incorporates a "human-centred AI approach should be adopted that puts the human interest at the centre" (9). They emphasise that digitising

vulnerable cultural resources must ensure "long-term preservation without undermining its values, significance, sense of community, and social impact" (10). Synthesising these perspectives indicates that performance archiving cannot depend on general-purpose, open-source AI models that oversimplify complex communal assets. Instead, sustainable digital heritage preservation requires an empirical, community-governed policy framework that employs indigenous digital protocols to ensure "ethical co-creation with cultural custodians" (Ugwu 15), so that technology serves as an interactive support tool rather than an extractive corporate replacement.

METHODOLOGY AND CONCEPTUAL FRAMEWORK

The methodological framework of this study evolves from traditional qualitative field research to an advanced computational processing pipeline, structured through a unified four-tiered conceptual model. Instead of treating Albert Lord's oral-formulaic theory, Walter Ong's psychodynamics of orality, Ngũgĩ wa Thiong'o's paradigm of Technauriture, and Clifford Geertz's interpretive ethnography as separate theoretical domains, this research integrates them into an operational methodology in which each framework informs distinct stages of data collection, processing, and textual analysis.

1. Institutional and Traditional Ethical Clearance

Prior to fieldwork, a dual-layered ethical clearance framework was implemented to ensure both institutional accountability and indigenous cultural authorisation. Institutional ethical clearance was obtained from the University of Jos, in accordance with academic protocols for research involving human communities and intangible cultural heritage. Simultaneously, recognising that Western institutional approval does not replace native self-governance, formal ethical clearance and an administrative mandate were secured from the traditional custodians of the culture. The Mupun Traditional Council, led by the paramount ruler, the Mishkom Mupun, Da Walle Yusuf Fwangbring, formally reviewed and approved the researcher's data collection activities. This royal authorisation served as a foundational element of the project's ethical framework, granting access to protected performance knowledge and ensuring adherence to the traditional laws of the Mupun nation.

2. Field Acquisition: Performance Simulation in the Mupun Core

Data collection was conducted in five historic Mupun villages on the Jos Plateau: Lankang, Kagu, Dyis, Jiblik, and Jing. Given that rapid urbanisation and contemporary changes have reduced the frequency of spontaneous evening storytelling, the study employed a controlled performance-simulation method. In each village, a traditional performance environment was recreated beneath communal shade trees during the evening. Master storytellers, such as Da Justin Lanibetle Snr in Kagu, were invited to perform before a live, intergenerational audience from the local community.

Following Clifford Geertz's principle of "thick description," these simulated performances were recorded using a Sony FX30 cinema camera. The use of cinematic capture was methodologically necessary to move beyond textual documentation and to record the complex "webs of significance" present in the performance space. The high-definition camera

documented the multi-vocal shifts of the griots, non-verbal micro-gestures, brief eye contact, and the dynamic feedback loop between the community audience and performers. This immersive ethnographic approach ensured that paralinguistic elements were documented as essential cultural indicators rather than incidental details.

3. Lord and Ong: Decoding Narrative Structure and Somatic Depth

After the acquisition phase in the five target villages, the transcription and textual analysis of the collected fables—such as *A mNdii Weel Bwoon gha e ingkhizim?* ("What Happened to Your Waist, Mr Wasp?") and *Dafwan gyet a ngutaa bang kook Jiraap* ("Why Mr Hare Has Long Ears")—were guided by Albert Lord's oral-formulaic theory and Walter Ong's psychodynamic principles. Lord's theory directed the analysis of performance scripts by moving focus away from rigid, literate expectations of textual stability. This approach enabled the identification of traditional formulaic themes, standardized opening calls (e.g., *Njinkook, Njinkook, fen yaa...*), and adaptive descriptions employed by performers to compose dynamically during simulated events. Ong's principles informed the structural analysis of somatic depth and vocal pacing within performances. The analysis applied Ong's concept of the "copious" or redundant flow of primary orality to explain storytellers' reliance on dense repetitions and rhythmic pauses. These repetitions were interpreted not as stylistic flaws but as essential psychological mechanisms that maintain communal audience engagement within a shared temporal framework.

4. The Technauritic Interface: Extending Ong into the Digital Age

The transition from transcription to computational processing is achieved by extending Walter Ong's binary framework through Ngũgĩ wa Thiong'o's paradigm of Technauriture. While Ong identified the shift from primary orality to print literacy as a restructuring of human consciousness that often suppresses oral dynamics, Technauriture demonstrates that digital networks and artificial intelligence generate a new, generative space. In this workflow, *Technauriture* integrates technology, *auriture*, and *textuality*, enabling the spoken word to avoid the limitations of print-based representation described by Ong. This methodology supports the development of a community-led digital pipeline, transforming the ancestral voice of the master storyteller into 2D-animated assets for YouTube distribution while preserving core performance elements.

5. Methodological Workflow Integration and Algorithmic Guardrails

The integration of these four theoretical frameworks is implemented through a structured, five-stage language processing pipeline designed to introduce "ethical friction" to counteract extractive data models:

1. Cinematic Acquisition (Geertz): High-definition capture in Lankang, Kagu, Dyis, Jiblik, and Jing preserves the high-context paralinguistic cues and community-performer feedback loops under the communal tree.
2. Orthographic Transcription (Lord & Ong): Original Mupun orthography is transcribed using literal interlinear glossing to preserve formulaic sequencing, while acoustic ideophones (e.g., *khiding-khiding*) are embedded directly as bracketed metadata tags.

3. Context-Enriched System Prompting (Technauriture): Instead of inputting raw text into an open-source Large Language Model (Gemini), a constrained system prompting framework imposes strict guardrails. The AI is assigned a sovereign role-play persona, instructing it to map acoustic tags onto synchronised character cuts and to respect localised ethical boundaries.
4. Visual Asset Generation (Technauriture): Structured text and visual markers generated by the AI are fed into an animation engine, translating physical gestures into culturally representative 2D cartoon assets.
5. Communal GatekeepCommunal Gatekeeping (Indigenous Data Sovereignty): Prior to public distribution, the rendered assets are reviewed by a panel of local elders and the Mupun Cultural Development Association (MUCDA) to ensure complete fidelity to the moral gravity (ret) of the live tradition.

The following chapters will demonstrate the claim above in details. Coding the two stories as performed as Mupun story (MN 1 and MN2) for further reference, the analysis will continually adopt MN1 and MN1 as reference in analysis. The raw data can be viewed on YouTube-<https://youtu.be/5DAICeJI2dc?si=wmWABuoBRHHZWlaP>

PERFORMANCE AND TEXTUAL ANALYSIS:

MN1: What Happened To Your Waist, Mr. Wasp ? Performed in Kagu

Mupun Text :

A müi WeelBwoonngghayiNdingkhizim

*Angyet khi shaar mo feer shi mpee feer. Tan mo
kat me retnyit fur be moyee an. Tong be
nkatngwesi ki ji sat min, ngwesi ki ji sat min,
dang nkatmokok a puusshi de paatjirmmo. Wen
yeeni dang an chin a yen müi tanji yak nmunsen
ii? Nkatkisi be nkokteng long
mofeernshwapmowen
nyakpwootengnimombootnsenmbwoonkaadenk
a di par puusni be ka nkatteng dull beannyeeni
vit nipuussi a cicin*

*Tan shaarfensimoyoolwaakuup, ngwesiyeeni ka
bit ki bang be din dull teng fin ki ghannjindyie
(retyit) fin di, kor nimoyee a kisizak. Bit bang
parr shi de paat be nkatngwesi ki dull, ngwesi*

Interpretation:

What happened to waist Mr Wasp

Performer:

One day, we (the community) asked Mr
Wasp, "What happened to your waist?"
(In response to the community, Mr Wasp
responded with the performer assuming
the role.)

Mr Wasp:

I had four friends who lived in four
different places. Each of them organised
a celebration at their own home. They

*ki dull shikwangfeersi mo. Tong le be
nkatbwoonsiweel den si pe an di. Wa a nsat di
kas, aangyetshi de paatsi be ndemben be
haiduk*

each sent me an invitation, and I found they had all chosen the same day for their celebrations. However, how could I attend four different functions in different locations at the same time? To avoid favouring anyone, I tied four ropes around my waist and gave each one an end. The plan was that whoever pulled their rope first and reminded me on the day would have me at their event. Sadly, they all decided to do that first thing in

MN2: Why Mr. Hare Has Long Ears"

Performed by Na Mary Maclean Dikwal , this narrative highlights the moral landscape of a rural subsistence-farming community, setting up a clash between laziness/deceit and communal justice

Mupun Text :

Dafwan gyet a ngutaa bang kook Jiraap. Par se wuyooltaa bang be wur dim waammap. Dafwan la mat. Shurepmomangpuusmo ji met kook retnyitnwur. Modi dak be pas yootaa be mat Dafwantal maar kom, pe mish fer. Dafwanlapnidyin ki maar dang be dyen fur, mmatpwoo ki dim a yil kas, niipaa tong pe bakchiremkomni ki dyin di yem di soo maar ni, wuwa sat nwarzaknikom ki laa des katdangmosuurchiremni a susuur. Mat sisuurchiremsiwaden ko!! Ka bit bang be Dafwanbe mang chirem de susuurni le nkulukwur dim wet pe sim nikurus-kureus. Wu yem chin a kisi dak wur sim chiremsiwurganpwak.

Interpretation:

(The Performer sits on a low stool beneath the tree. The COMMUNITY gathers around him. The Performer's eyes close for a moment, then open slowly, fixing on the group.)

Performer: (clearing voice) Mr Hare was an excellent drummer, best known for accompanying women's folk songs. On one of his outings to a distant village, he returned home with a young lady. Wow, Mr Hare is married; all the women in the community organised a dance to celebrate his good fortune. (Demonstrating by singing)
After a few days, it rained, and Hare's wife asked for a piece of land to plant her

*Tar buuk kom chin, Dafwan sat mmat fin zaak nishurep (mat pwoo) mo ki dim a yil kas. Tar Toot kom ji wul, wu chin sat di a ki si, mat pwoo ki dim a yil kas. De wur ki chan a pwo ret komninwardak .Dafwantal pe shin.par, si be wur sat nulanidigan toot kom, dee din mbi yak ni dak. Dafwanyem pe wat kom a nniyemowu ji ki nintul, mat wurretniyitni mish fer a da-shiit. Nniyeemo kat mo jar wat komndayunyaksimotangndibenmomo ji ndo mat mo ji den mmaar .Dafwan ji kat waar ki dar be wurnimo a mat nbe tap komhong? Wu dim dar sat war ni ka pa wa yak si kas be din nbaamsar war ni ka pan wa yak si kas be din nbaamsarmpaa. Laareepsidokkitik. D a f w a n b a m s a r n u a r n k p a k , sarsidimbaa**drak**. Wur chin-chin sarsi chi yoikipatlarepsi. Wur yawuu war shin do dako, pa man dinnong? Pa man sarkul fin? Nong ka yak di ba'amsarkulnpa be pa nbalamuut da ko'.pifsarsibba'at dak. Dafwanba ki sarku shin war zak, sarkul dim ba'at. Wu shin, shikul,war, shikuldimbaat. dafwan wet taat shin ndibenrep.puus nep, nenkommo ji kat Dafwan ki taat, moyaawurmo dim shin Mishkoom. Mishkoom sat njepzilangmoyawur dim kini a fur, mobwetkomwuur shin ting dang mobuetwurnsong ting nuele wet taat di. Dafwangyet ki kom fin a kurnat, a di moyitnwaar wet taat shin ting toot kom le sinwurchiroong*

groundnuts. Mr Hare says (Hmmmmmm), (performer changes voice into the character of the Hare), "I have enough land for that, but newly married women do not go to the farm in this community. Her duty was to prepare the seed while he cleared the land. He also informed her that there is always an excellent yield in the community once they plant fried groundnuts, so she should fry the seeds."

Performer: Of course, his wife obeyed and did precisely what he asked her to do. Every morning, Hare would fetch a good quantity of the fried seeds to the field, sit under a tree, and eat them all. This is how he used up the entire supply of seeds.

When it was time for the wedding, Hare still told his wife that new wives do not go to the farm, and when harvest time came, he said the same. However, every day he kept telling her how well their groundnut crop was flourishing. "But what will I do to keep this secret?" he asked himself. He had an idea; he began stealing others' groundnuts to take home.

The people were disturbed by the widespread stealing on their farm. So they collected enough gum from trees and shaped it into a lady, making her stand on the farm. When Mr Hare came around and saw the lady, he ridiculed her and demanded that she leave, or he would slap her. When she refused to go or speak, he slapped her on the cheek, trapping his right hand there. He sent his left hand, and it too was trapped. He decided to kick her with both legs, and that was how he became trapped. Later, the farm owners found him hanging from the trap. They took him to the king. The king then ordered that the youths "hang him by the ears on a tree in the town square". This caused his ears to grow long, but before this, the hare (rabbit) had normal ears.



Plate 1: A master storyteller, Da, Justin Lani-Betle SNR, performing the A mii Weel Bwoon gha e Ndingkhizim? At Kagu^{2nd} March, 2025. Photo credit David Iliya

PERFORMANCE AND TEXTUAL ANALYSIS: MN1 VS. MN2

The structural and aesthetic mechanics of *Njingkook* storytelling theatre rely on an interdependent relationship between the performer's physical embodiment and the audience's active critical presence. The following comparative analysis decodes the live ethnographic executions of MN1 (*A mii Weel Bwoon gha e Ndingkhizim?* performed by Da Justin Lanibetle SNR in Kagu) and MN2 (*Dafwangyet a ngutaa bang kook Jiraap* performed by Na Mary Maclean Dikwal) across the critical performance sub-themes.

1. Performance Rhythm

Performance rhythm dictates the temporal economy of the oral narrative, balancing structural speed against aesthetic retention (*ret*). Whereas in, **MN1 (Mr. Wasp)**: The rhythm of this performance is tight, urgent, and cyclical. It begins with an abrupt interrogative frame from the community, establishing a collaborative cadence. The performer drives the temporal flow forward by mimicking the rapid, simultaneous invitations and subsequent dawn pulling of the four ropes. The rapid structural pacing accelerates toward the etiological closure, moving the plot rapidly from initial complication to the physical compression of the wasp's waist. While in **MN2 (Mr. Hare)**: The rhythm here is layered and expansive, unfolding in alternating somatic waves. It opens slowly with a formal prologue establishing setting and character, shifts into a musical cadence ("demonstrating by singing"), and then decelerates into a daily, repetitive agricultural cycle. The rhythm speeds up sharply during the climactic interaction with the Gum Lady, utilizing sequential, quick-paced physical beats to mirror each trapped limb before slowing down to a solemn judicial march before the King.

2. Gesture

Gesticulation transforms the physical space (*men*) into a structural map of the narrative's moral reality (*ret*). **MN1 (Mr. Wasp):** The performer operates with outward kinetic economy, using highly localized somatic tensions to depict the text. Gestures focus heavily on the torso and waistline; the performer physically strains his body to manifest the outward pulling of the four competitive friends. The physical act of tightening the imaginary ropes serves as a visual layout of internal stress and structural tension. While in **MN2 (Mr. Hare):** The performance features highly illustrative, physical gestures. The griot uses distinct movements to delineate domestic duties: the action of frying seeds, sitting lazily under a tree to eat the crop, and the aggressive, successive physical movements of slapping and kicking the sticky effigy. The climax requires the performer to hold their own limbs rigid to physically manifest the trap.



Plate 2: The performer, Na, Mary Maclean Dikwal, in action, demonstrating through body language in Dangmet-Kagu organised re-enactment.

3. Audience Participation

Audience participation acts as the ultimate judicial and validation apparatus within the live performance space. **MN1 (Mr. Wasp):** The audience initiates the narrative frame by posing the foundational etiological question: "*What happened to your waist?*" This immediate interaction draws the community into the performance space as active co-interrogators. The audience's ongoing reactions validate the moral warning regarding peer pressure and conflicting loyalties. **MN2 (Mr. Hare):** The community functions as both the immediate audience gathered around the

stool and as an active character within the fable's world. The audience provides the choruses for the festive dances, gasps at the violation of domestic customs (the fried groundnut deceit), and nods in validation as the community within the story crafts the collective justice of the Gum Lady effigy.

4. Voice Modulation

Vocal variation allows a single performer to enact multiple personas, moving seamlessly between narrative commentary and dramatic characterization. This is seen in the performance MN1 (Mr. Wasp): The performer uses a direct technique of performative ventriloquism. He modulates his voice from a measured, objective community narrator into a defensive, strained first-person voice for Mr. Wasp. The pitch captures the anxiety of a character attempting to appease multiple forces simultaneously, ending in a sigh of self-reproach: *"It is pretty unfortunate, but I blame myself"*. While in MN2 (Mr. Hare): The storyteller demonstrates deep paralinguistic range. She transitions from an introductory narrative register into a deep, deceptive, throat-clearing vocalization (*"Hmmmmmm"*) to portray the trickster Hare. This voice shifts from manipulative arrogance when lying to the wife or ridiculing the silent Gum Lady, to a humbled tone when brought before the town square.

5. Repetition

Repetition in the performance serves an essential mnemonic and cognitive purpose, functioning as Walter Ong's "copious flow" to maintain structural clarity. MN1 (Mr. Wasp): The performance relies on mathematical and situational redundancy. The text repeats the numeric anchor—*four friends, four different places, four celebrations, four ropes*—to reinforce the structural patterns of the trap. The continuous verbal looping of the word *"pulling"* emphasizes the constant tension that eventually alters the wasp's anatomy. MN2 (Mr. Hare): The text utilizes thematic and cyclical structural repetition. The narrative loops through the phrase *"new wives do not go to the farm"* across multiple agricultural cycles, first during planting, then weeding, and finally harvest. This continuous repetition deepens the weight of Hare's laziness before the communal intervention occurs.

6. Improvisation

Memory to recollect details sometimes skip the narrator performer however, skills in Improvisation allows the griot to dynamically tailor traditional motifs to the immediate environmental and psychological feedback of the gathered audience. In MN1 (Mr. Wasp): The performer adjusts the dialogue of self-reflection based on the direct gaze of the community. He leans into the allegory of social obligation, tweaking the emotional gravity of the warning to fit the social dynamics of the Kagu village square. While in MN2 (Mr. Hare): The storyteller inserts immediate performative markers, such as vocal pauses (*"Hmmmmmm"*) and localized performance prompts, (songs, saying) to gauge audience focus. The musical interludes and descriptions of the community's frustration with theft allow the performer to prolong or accelerate the narrative tension depending on how closely the listeners are tracking the story's moral development.

7. Performer-Audience Interaction

In both MN1 and MN2, the performer-audience interaction operates as a living, democratic feedback loop that directly shapes the aesthetic balance between material display (*men*) and ethical truth (*ret*). In MN1, this interaction is structured as an ongoing conversation between a questioning collective and a self-correcting individual, reinforcing the community's role as the arbiter of social justice. In MN2, the interaction is structured as a shared moral journey where the performer exposes human vices (laziness and deceit) while the audience actively supports the structural path toward communal balance. In both cases, the immediate feedback loop ensures that the final etiological conclusions are experienced not as passive entertainment, but as active, shared legal precedents for the Mupun community.

REIMAGINING *NJINGKOOK* IN THE DIGITAL AGE: THE AI INTERFACE

To preserve these vulnerable oral performance systems, the study migrates the traditional *Njingkook* texts into digital channels through the paradigm of Technauriture. The traditional process is captured across multi-stage digital translations:



Plate 3: The digital environment on YouTube. Showing actions between the Wasp and his friend in conversation mood

The Technauritic Pipeline

[Primary Oral Stage] → [Cinema Capture (Sony FX30)] → [AI Engine Transcription & Prompting] → [CGI/Cartoon Animation Assets] → [YouTube Archive Distribution]

The translation of the live performance into a community-governed digital asset followed a deliberate five-stage protocol designed to introduce "ethical friction" against extractive data models:

1. **Cinematic Acquisition:** The live performance of *A mii Weel Bwoon gha e Ndingkhizim?* by master storyteller Da Justin Lanibetle SNR was captured using a Sony FX30 cinema camera. This step preserved non-verbal paralinguistic cues, spatial dynamics under the communal tree, and audience-performer feedback loops.
2. **Orthographic Transcription:** The performance was transcribed in its original West Chadic Mupun orthography to maintain linguistic sovereignty. Onomatopoeic drumming markers (*khiding-khiding*) and ideophones were retained verbatim rather than being pre-filtered through English semantic structures.
3. **Context-Enriched Prompt Engineering:** Rather than feeding raw text into the general-purpose LLM (Gemini), a **System Prompts Framework** was established. The AI was assigned a highly specific persona: *"You are an expert digital archivist collaborating with the Mupun community to preserve the indigenous aesthetics of Njingkook storytelling."*
4. **Visual Asset Generation:** The structured text outputs and structural markers generated by the AI were fed into an animation rendering pipeline to translate physical gestures and narrative actions into culturally representative 2D cartoon assets.
5. **Communal Gatekeeping:** Before distribution on public platforms like YouTube, the rendered draft was reviewed by a panel of local elders to verify that the animation did not distort the moral gravity (*ret*) or violate traditional visual taboos.

Using the AI model **Gemini**, transcribed data from narrative ("*Why the Wasp Has a Thin Waist*") was utilized to convert traditional oral collection into dynamic, cartoon-like media assets (video on Youtube: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=0ak9weqWJEo&t=7s>). The AI translates the structural markers, such as the onomatopoeic drum rhythms ("*khiding-khiding*") and physical gestures recorded via cinema line cameras into animated sequences. This process allows the "ancestral voice" of the master griot to be preserved in an "evergreen" archive accessible to younger generations on platforms like YouTube.

THE RISKS OF DIGITAL COLONIALISM IN TECHNAURITIC TRANSLATION

The integration of artificial intelligence and automated technologies into the preservation of

indigenous oral performance systems has introduced profound ontological and epistemic hazards. At a macro-systemic level, general-purpose Large Language Models (LLMs) and standard algorithmic frameworks operate on a predatory "universalist logic" rooted in data extraction capitalism, wherein localized cultural knowledge systems are treated as raw, extractable commodities. This structural approach strips high-context oral performance genres of their intrinsic socio-historical gravity, transforming deeply communal epistemologies into fragmented datasets designed for western-centric processing architectures.

As Nick Couldry and Ulises A. Mejias observe, contemporary data colonialism mirrors historical colonial land grabs by appropriating human life and cultural production directly through digital tracking and algorithmic processing, effectively establishing "a new era in human history where data is continuous with colonialism" (337). When general-purpose computational tools indiscriminately scrape indigenous oral texts, they run the risk of digital colonialism, a process where corporate digital platforms strip complex, sacred moral frameworks of their structural boundaries and reduce them to transient, commodified, and viral pieces of westernized consumer entertainment.

This threat becomes critically acute when domesticating the technological experiment within the specific, high-context framework of the *Njingkook* tradition. Standard transformer and linear AI architectures are fundamentally bounded by Eurocentric, mathematical logic that is structurally incapable of encoding what indigenous performance critics define as "spiritual intentionality". In the *Njingkook* ontology, a narrative is never a mere linear sequence of textual signs; it is a holistic, multi-sensory event where meaning is tied to the physical environment, the spiritual proximity of the ancestors (*Yil Nji*), and the immediate, improvisational feedback of the participating community. Because digital algorithms parse data through flat, secularized linguistic modeling, an uncritical AI translation risks flattening the recursive, cyclical temporalities and deeply layered semantic metaphors characteristic of Mupun storytelling into a rigid, westernized narrative line. Shoshana Zuboff warns that such data-extractive configurations function as an uninvited "expropriation of critical human experience" (12). Without deliberate intervention, automated engines can easily misinterpret or entirely erase the subtle tonal variations, rhythmic pauses, and localized ethical boundaries that master griots rely on to convey authoritative truths.

Consequently, applying general-purpose AI tools to the *Njingkook* corpus poses an immediate risk of digital desecration and epistemic bias. For example, when an AI model processes an animal fable like narrative ("Why the Wasp Has a Thin Waist") or a parallel moral test like narrative ("Hare and Daboo in a Dance Performance"), it evaluates the transcription through a secularized lens of generalized folklore. In doing so, the machine strips away the "*ret*" the inner, non-depleting spiritual goodness and didactic severity that anchors the story within Mupun relational ethics and socio-natural ontology.

To aggressively counteract this localized epistemic gap and prevent the distortion of ancestral voices, this paper insists on a radical shift away from open-source extraction models toward highly governed-source frameworks. By introducing community-led custodianship, establishing "ethical friction" through indigenous digital protocols, and embedding an explicit layer of communal verification by local elders, the Mupun community can actively govern how its traditional cultural expressions are digitally modeled. This ensures that the technauritic

translation functions as an authentic, controlled extension of the community's sovereign voice rather than an extractive tool for global data consumption

To protect the rights and cultural property of the Mupun nation, the study outlines a comprehensive policy framework rooted in **Indigenous Data Sovereignty (IDS)**. This framework regulates how digital assets are generated, archived, and commercialized:

1. **Foundational Sovereignty & Collection:** The Mupun community remains the primary architect of the archiving process, ensuring that recordings meet global digital standards without ceding ownership to external entities.
2. **Indigenous Digital Protocols:** Technical safeguards must be built into the repository to introduce "ethical friction," preventing general AI scrapers from harvesting sacred knowledge or violating traditional taboos.
3. **Communal Verification:** Before any animated or AI-generated output is disseminated publicly, it must pass through an iterative review by local elders and recognized custodians to ensure absolute cultural fidelity.
4. **Equitable Benefit-Sharing:** Intellectual Property (IP) rights and any revenue generated through digital channels (such as YouTube analytics) must be managed through formal community unions, like the Mupun Cultural Development Association (MUCDA), to fund local infrastructural and cultural sustainability initiatives

COMPARATIVE ANALYSIS OF LIVE AND ANIMATED PERFORMANCE TYPOLOGIES

To critically evaluate how the *Njingkook* tradition operates when migrated from communal physical spaces to digital channels, a direct comparative analysis must be executed between the live ethnographic performance of master storyteller Da Justin Lanibetle SNR and the resulting AI-animated multimedia asset distributed on YouTube. This structural comparison exposes the precise points where the digital translation expands access, as well as where it risks enacting an epistemic flattening of indigenous temporalities and performance philosophies. The table below breaks down these two performance models across three primary aesthetic, technical, and socio-cultural domains:

Aesthetic and Performance Domain	Live Ethnographic Performance (Da Justin Lanibetle) DOCX	AI/Digital Animated Asset (YouTube Distribution)	Critical Epistemic Evaluation
Somatic & Paralinguistic Execution	The storyteller utilizes multi-vocal ventriloquism, altering vocal timbre dynamically between the detached narrator and the defensive, stressed tone of Mr. Wasp. Meaning is generated via micro-gestures: eye contact, body leaning, and physical tension.	The animation relies on a stylized, linear visual representation of the wasp being pulled by four ropes. Vocal tracks are flattened into a singular, compressed audio channel optimized for digital streaming platforms.	Loss of Somatic Depth: The digital asset achieves <i>men</i> (visual clarity) but sacrifices the somatic elasticity of the performer. The algorithmic translation struggles to encode the subtle bodily shifts that signify ancestral authority, reducing a multi-sensory event to a flat visual sign.
Temporal Pacing & Redundancy	Employs Walter Ong's "copious" flow. The performer uses rhythmic pauses and repetitive phrasings to maintain a shared temporal space with the audience, adjusting pace based on immediate audience reactions (murmurs, nods).	The narrative arc is condensed into a standardized, fast-paced time bracket suitable for internet consumption metrics (e.g., YouTube algorithms). Redundancy is stripped to keep user engagement high.	Algorithmic Compression: The temporal economy of digital networks forces a structural violence upon Njingkook. By stripping the "copious" repetitions necessary for traditional cognitive retention, the digital platform alters the psychological dynamics of the oral performance to serve attention-economy.
The Inscription of <i>Ret</i> (Didactic/Spiritual Truth)	The communal audience functions as a live critical authority. The etiological conclusion ("That is why the wasp has a thin waist") is experienced as a shared, heavy moral reality regarding the dangers of conflicting loyalties and peer pressure.	The performance is viewed in isolation by a decentralized, global digital audience. The comments section replaces the live interactive chorus, transforming a civic pedagogical lesson into a scrollable piece of cultural content.	The Commodification Risk: This exemplifies the threat of data colonialism. When stripped of its localized, high-context framework, the severe ethical warning of the Mupun worldview risks being misread by global consumers as a quaint, secular animal fable.

5. This comparative dissonance demonstrates that an uncritical reliance on general-purpose AI tools and corporate video hosting services results in a severe distortion of indigenous performance philosophies. In the live *Njingkook* matrix, external material presentation (*men*) is strictly subjugated to serve internal, non-depleting spiritual and didactic goodness (*ret*), creating a space where physical transformations function as ACTIVE legal precedents of individual accountability within the community. The digital version, by contrast, prioritizes visual capture and rapid pacing, which naturally elevates *men* while compressing the "copious" repetitions and paralinguistic pauses necessary to sustain *ret*. Consequently, to prevent the total commodification of Mupun folklore into flat, Westernized consumer entertainment, the digital asset cannot be treated as a self-sustaining archive; it must be anchored within a community-governed framework that uses indigenous digital protocols to manage how its cultural properties are interpreted, accessed, and valued globally

KEY FINDINGS

The study Empirical Findings include (What was observed and analyzed) :

1. Comparative structural analysis between the live village performances and the YouTube animations reveals that standard digital compression prioritizes visual elements (*men*) while active algorithms flatten the somatic depth, paralinguistic pauses, and "copious" repetitions essential to sustaining the philosophical weight of *ret*.
2. The implementation workflow proved that while standard Large Language Models (LLMs) successfully translate literal vocabulary, they are structurally incapable of independently decoding acoustic ideophones (like *khiding-khiding*) or capturing localized relational ethics without heavily constrained, community-designed system prompts.

On Conceptual Arguments (How the study theorizes the tradition) the paper finds that:

1. The study argues against traditional, Eurocentric scholarship that frames African oral performance as a frozen, static artifact of a pre-literate past. Instead, it positions *Njingkook* as a sovereign, living "techno-vernacular" practice capable of continuous transformation.
2. **Operationalisation of Aesthetic Grammar:** The research asserts that Mupun performance aesthetics are governed by a strict binary where material, surface display (*men*) is structurally subjugated to serve and illuminate internal, non-depleting didactic truth (*ret*).
3. The study extends Walter Ong's classic framework which viewed the transition from primary orality to textuality as a strict flattening of human consciousness by proving that Ngũgĩ wa Thiong'o's paradigm of Technauriture offers a generative third space where digital media can revitalize rather than erase oral cultures.

On the proposed Policy Arguments for structural framework:

1. The study argues for a systemic shift away from open-source data scraping and toward highly "governed-source" frameworks to protect indigenous knowledge from the predatory architectures of digital colonialism.
2. The paper outlines an operational policy model rooted in Indigenous Data Sovereignty (IDS) where the Mupun Cultural Development Association (MUCDA) serves as the legal and administrative custodian of the digital assets.
3. The policy framework argues that AI-assisted indigenous cultural preservation must explicitly incorporate community-led guardrails, including iterative verification review layers by local elders, and equitable benefit-sharing models to fund local infrastructure.

CONCLUSION

The aesthetic matrix of the *Njingkook* tradition, as preserved within the West Chadic-speaking Mupun society of Central Nigeria, operates as a sophisticated philosophical instrument where material beauty (*men*) is structurally subjugated to serve immaterial, didactic goodness (*ret*). The principal analytical findings of this study demonstrate that an uncritical digital migration of this oral tradition results in a severe epistemic compression; standard algorithms and internet attention-economy metrics favor visual *men* while actively flattening the somatic depth, vocal range, and "copious" structural repetitions that are essential to sustaining the moral and pedagogical weight of *ret*.

This research offers a dual theoretical contribution to contemporary scholarship. First, it advances African theatre studies by conceptualizing *Njingkook* not as a static historical artifact, but as a living techno-vernacular practice where physical transformations function as active, portable legal precedents of individual accountability within the community. Second, it extends the digital humanities paradigm of Technauriture by providing an empirical, decolonial blueprint, rooted in Indigenous Data Sovereignty (IDS)—that demonstrates how localized oral performance systems can actively resist the predatory, data-extractive frameworks of modern data colonialism.

Acknowledging the methodological limitations of this study is critical for future applications. The empirical observations were constrained by the use of *performance simulations* rather than entirely spontaneous evening storytelling sessions, which may marginally alter the organic, highly unpredictable nature of real-time community interactions. Furthermore, the constrained Large Language Model prompting pipeline remains highly dependent on pre-transcribed orthographic data, which limits its scalability for entirely unwritten indigenous languages. Consequently, future research should investigate the implementation of automated speech recognition (ASR) systems trained specifically on low-resource Chadic languages to bypass textual translation bottlenecks. Additional longitudinal studies are required to measure how long-term engagement with these animated media platforms impacts cultural and linguistic retention among decentralized, urbanized indigenous youths.

Ultimately, the implications for AI-assisted indigenous cultural preservation are clear:

generative computational tools must never be treated as neutral or self-governing archival curators. To prevent the commodification and distortion of ancestral voices into flattened global entertainment, AI-assisted workflows must be intentionally slowed down by "ethical friction". Digital heritage preservation can only achieve true decolonial utility when technical workflows are systematically subjugated to community-governed policy frameworks, local elder verification layers, and traditional institutional unions like the Mupun Cultural Development Association (MUCDA).

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